

Intercepting routes — `(.)folder` (the modal pattern)

Live demo: `/gallery` (click a photo → modal; refresh the modal URL → full page) **Code:** `src/app/gallery/`

What it is

Intercepting routes let you load a route from elsewhere in the app **inside the current layout**, instead of navigating away. The classic use is a **modal**: clicking a thumbnail opens a detail view as an overlay on **soft** (client-side) navigation, but visiting/refreshing that same URL loads the **full** page.

The matchers

Convention	Meaning
<code>(.)folder</code>	Intercept a route at the same level
<code>(..)folder</code>	Intercept one level up
<code>(..)(..)folder</code>	Two levels up
<code>(...)folder</code>	Intercept from the app root

This demo uses `(.)photo` — intercepting the sibling `photo` route.

Files in this folder (combines intercepting + a parallel slot)

Path	Role
<code>gallery/layout.tsx</code>	Renders <code>children</code> (grid) and the <code>modal</code> slot
<code>gallery/page.tsx</code>	The photo grid; links to <code>/gallery/photo/[id]</code>
<code>gallery/photo/[id]/page.tsx</code>	Full page view (hard load / refresh)
<code>gallery/@modal/(.)photo/[id]/page.tsx</code>	The intercepted modal (soft nav)
<code>gallery/@modal/default.tsx</code>	<code>null</code> when no modal is open

How it works

- On `/gallery`, the `@modal` slot has no match → `default.tsx` renders `null`.
- Click a photo → **soft navigation** to `/gallery/photo/1`. The `(.)photo` interceptor (inside `@modal`) renders **over** the grid, because the grid (`children`) and the modal (`modal` slot) render in parallel.
- Refresh** `/gallery/photo/1` → it's a hard load, so interception **doesn't** apply: the real `photo/[id]/page.tsx` full page renders.

The modal closes with `router.back()` (backdrop or Close button).

When to use

Image lightboxes, "quick view" dialogs, login modals — anything that should be a shareable/refreshable URL and an in-context overlay.

Interview Q&A

- **Q: What do `(.)`, `(..)`, `(...)` mean?** Where to intercept *from*: same level, one level up, and the app root, respectively.
- **Q: Why does the modal become a full page on refresh?** Interception only happens on **soft** (client) navigation. A hard load hits the real route directly.
- **Q: Why is a parallel `@modal` slot used with the interceptor?** So the modal renders **on top of** the existing page (both render at once), rather than replacing it.